



**REAP Form
(for Applicants of 2025 Intake)**

The Re-entry Action Plan (REAP) is a formal document that represents a scholar's commitment to honor the conditions of the Australia Awards Scholarships (see Scholarship Handbook section 4.2). It is a mechanism that allows scholars to apply what they have learned in Australia to contribute to Philippine development through a meaningful project in an organisation or community.

I. RELEVANCE OF THE REAP. The REAP should clearly and succinctly explain how the delivery of its proposed output or outputs will improve the services or performance of the Host Organisation and ultimately contribute to the achievement of the goals set in the Philippine Government's Ambisyon Natin 2040, and the goals of the Australian Government in the Philippines.

Fill out the following sections after reading these required documents.

Name of Proponent	Chlarizel Dianne H. Pangan-Villa Agustin
REAP Title	COMMUNIC-ACTION Manual: Integration of Strategic Interdepartmental Communications in the Department of Transportation (DOTr)
REAP Objective	Integrate interdepartmental communication within the Department of Transportation (DOTr) through improved and enhanced coordination between the DOTr-Central Communications Team and its sectoral and attached agencies, with a unified, standardized communication system, resulting in cohesive and consistent dissemination of information to the public and transport stakeholders within a year of the implementation of the REAP – leading to enhanced public trust, engagement, and Department's credibility. This is slated to be the pioneering blueprint and roadmap for the strategic interdepartmental communication plan of the Department, encompassing framework and protocols.
Name of Host Organisation	Department of Transportation
Description of the Host Organisation and relation to REAP	The REAP is highly relevant and beneficial for the DOTr as an executive department of the national government tasked to steer the development and regulation of dependable and coordinated transportation system network. The Department relies heavily on effective communication to fulfill its mandate — of which is specifically under the functions of its Communications and Commuter Affairs Office (CCAO). The plan supports the DOTr-CCAO's critical tasks of managing and implementing communication-related works, through the enhancement of communication processes. The REAP aims to integrate interdepartmental communication in the Department, fostering improved coordination and relationship amongst the communications teams. This is crucial for a national government agency as multifaceted as the DOTr — with 18 sectoral and attached agencies under its umbrella, and overseeing all transport systems in the aviation and airports, railways, maritime, and road transport. This ensures that all communication teams are well-aligned in communication efforts, leading to more effective operations and better service delivery.

	As one of the REAP's core objectives is to improve public trust and engagement, communication processes will be streamlined by the implementation of unified communication system and setting of clearer communication flows that aim to foster high-level accountability and transparency. Through this, the Department's communication teams can better engage with the public and its stakeholders. As the COMMUNIC-ACTION Manual is slated to be the pioneering blueprint and roadmap of the DOTr's strategic interdepartmental communications, it provides a formalized and solidified direction and reference for future communication initiatives within the DOTr and its communication officers — ensuring continuity and sustainability of relevance. Ultimately, the REAP is not just a standalone initiative or proposal, but a CALL TO ACTION directly connected to the overarching vision of the DOTr: to transform the country's transportation systems to global standards. As the Department delivers and fulfills its mission, so must its communication excellence. Thus, the manual serves as the DOTr's critical catalyst to achieve its objectives by the integration of interdepartmental communication into its paradigm. It is also envisioned to be a fundamental driver for public and stakeholders' trust and engagement — all of which are essential components to realizing the country's world-class transportation network.
BACKGROUND INFORMATION	
Problem / Opportunity	Strategic, interdepartmental communication has been a building block of an overall improved government communication paradigm. Hence, the REAP serves as the DOTr's anchor to address the need to have a cohesive and unified system amongst communication teams, as this absence hampers efficient communication — crucial to earning public trust and maintaining credibility in delivering public service. The current challenge on diverse messaging across DOTr's social media platforms and its sectoral and attached agencies, coupled with public insights received, presents an opportunity to improve and solidify communication strategies and foster greater alignment for better information dissemination, addressing inconsistent messaging, missed opportunities for proper public engagement, and misdirected resources – paving way to champion transparency vis-a-vis transportation matters, and help in managing crisis communication. The following are the national and international academic researches and industry reports supporting the view—demonstrating the challenge's existence and lending credibility to the study's proposed solution. The Organization for Economic Co-operation and Development (OECD) Report (Building Trust to Reinforce Democracy: Key Findings from the 2021 OECD Survey on Drivers of Trust in Public Institutions). This is a cross-national survey with over 50,000 responses across 22 OECD countries, underscoring the need to have well-integrated government communication approaches to achieve key policy objectives and build public trust. It aims to put forth the need to invest in public integrity. Reflections on the Current Philippine Trust Landscape by the Philippine Trust Index. The study delves into the levels and drivers of trust amongst Filipinos across the archipelago. Its research in 2019 showed that people's trust towards the government was recorded as moderate—from 80% in 2017 to only 76% in 2019. The 2022 Edelman Trust Barometer. Annually, it releases reports showing decline in public trust in governments globally, underscoring that inconsistent messaging and lack of transparency are the factors contributing

	to it. It likewise shows that some institutions worldwide are trusted by less than half of their people. In 2023, a new report and study was released, showing the lack of faith in societal institutions due to disinformation and division, among others. The Contribution of Government Communication Capacity to Achieving Good Governance Outcomes. This Rapporteur's report delves into the importance of government communication capacity in generating good governance outcomes. It highlights the crucial role of transparent and consistent communication in furthering government stability and credibility. Effects of the Medium of Interdepartmental Communication, Interdepartmental Communicator on Organisational Performance: A Case Study of County Government of "L", Kenya. The findings emphasized the vital role of interdepartmental communication strategies and mediums in improving the organizational performance within the structure of a particular government department. Grunig's Excellence Model in Public Relations (1992). This model underlines that public relations must be guided by strategic planning. It also plays an indispensable role in decision-making by enjoining leaders to improve their relationships with stakeholders. This supports the REAP's strategic planning aspect—wherein effective communication should not be haphazard but grounded in strategic approach. The REAP is intricately aligned with the core goals embedded in the Philippine Government's Development Plan as communication and achieving connectivity in the Department's four sectors are amongst its priority sectors. Cultivating a high-trust society calls for the government to integrate unified, transparent, and citizen-centered approaches – thus, strategic interdepartmental communication system is vital. The REAP also harmonizes with the Australia's Southeast Asia Economic Strategy to 2040, targeting the priority sectors of Education and Skills, Digital Economy, and Infrastructure.
BENEFICIARIES	
Direct Beneficiary	The COMMUNIC-ACTION Manual is slated to benefit its intended beneficiaries through strategic, interdepartmental communication integration and clear delineation of the DOTr's communication processes – presenting long-term impact in the Department's endeavors: • The DOTr-Central Communication Team and Communication Teams of DOTr's 18 Sectoral and Attached Agencies. With improved coordination and more cohesive relationship, communication efforts and information dissemination will be more effective, efficient, and seamless. Moreover, in times of managing crisis and emergencies, the plan will greatly be of help to enhance the Department's crisis communication approach — ensuring the accurate, timely, and consistent reporting and circulation of information to the public. • The Public and Commuters. They shall benefit from receiving clear, consistent, and timely information vis-à-vis all transport-related concerns, updates, and developments — leading to enhanced credibility and transparency, and enhanced public trust towards the government. • Transport Stakeholders. Effective communication fosters future-forward partnerships. Thus, the REAP aims to enable better stakeholder engagement, and ensure that communication channels are established and protocols are in place to effectively manage such instances and maintain stakeholders' confidence. Meanwhile, the DOTr's different offices could benefit from the REAP in the long run, enabling them to have proper and streamlined coordination with the DOTr's communication teams.

Gender Equality, Disability, and Social Inclusion (GEDSI)	The COMMUNIC-ACTION Manual champions smart, inclusive communication practices and policies anchored on Gender Equality, Disability, and Social Inclusion (GEDSI), thus, benefitting women and the marginalized groups. Gender-Inclusive Language and Messaging. Communication strategies will be crafted and tailored to ensure inclusive messages, respecting the concerns and needs of the aforesaid group, including incorporation of gender-neutral language in all communication protocols and frameworks to obviate the reinforcement of gender stereotypes. Accessibility Standards and Measures. The communication channels will be made easily accessible to all, wherein alternative formats like braille, audio, and easy-to-read versions will be provided. Representation. Necessary efforts will be employed to ensure a diverse representation within the DOTr communication teams and its sectoral and attached agencies — ensuring everyone in the room is considered in the process. GEDSI-aligned Awareness Campaigns. Safety and accessibility concerns, among others, shall be at the core of awareness campaigns, to genuinely serve the marginalized groups' varying needs and unique challenges. Consultation, Engagement, and Training. Sensitization and training sessions shall be provided for the targeted DOTr staff and its sectoral and attached agencies vis-à-vis diversity and inclusion to forge a more inclusive culture and communication practices for public and stakeholders' engagement. GEDSI-Framework Standard Opportunities. It shall serve as reference and standard for the crafting of other communication plans, through a framework for promoting GEDSI principles in all aspects of interdepartmental communication. To importantly note, various DOTr projects and initiatives are GEDSI-embedded—among these are the North-South Commuter Railway (NSCR) Project, Davao Public Transport Modernization Project, Public Utility Vehicle Modernization Program (PUVMP), and a long list more. Thus, it is ensured that this will ultimately be applied in the REAP's fulfillment, contributing to a more equitable transport system for all and greater public trust in the Department's communication efforts.
Climate Change Adaptation, Disaster Risk Reduction and Environmental Protection	By the integration of strategic interdepartmental communication into the communication ecosystem of the Department of Transportation (DOTr), making it streamlined, unified, and standardized, the COMMUNIC-ACTION Manual shall enhance the effectiveness and efficiency of crucial responses to climate-related disasters and environmental challenges — online and offline. With the cohesive coordination facilitated by the REAP, resulting in more efficient and effective communication processes between the DOTr and its sectoral and attached agencies, smooth dissemination of critical information and directives relating to climate-related risks and disasters will be enabled, empowering the Department to take proactive measures to mitigate potential risks. As laid out in the REAP, the standardized, strategic interdepartmental communication system, framework, and protocols provides for more consistent and seamless flow of conveying information to the public and transport stakeholders, igniting awareness and preparedness amid climate-related events, as well as ensuring the overall welfare of the riding public. In addition, the focus of the REAP on cohesive and consistent information

	dissemination, through providing unified communication channels, can support and amplify the initiatives aimed at promoting sustainable transportation practices and reduction of carbon emissions — of which the DOTr has been at the forefront — including the roll-out of the Active Transport Program, EDSA Busway, EDSA Greenways, the establishment of bike lanes under its road transport sector, and other environment-friendly transport projects in its different sectors of aviation and airports, maritime, and railways. In terms of implementation, environment-friendly materials and digital platforms will be utilized to minimize carbon footprints connected to traditional communication methods. Sustainability is one of the core bedrocks of the COMMUNIC-ACTION Manual; hence, it will set a precedent for eco-conscious ways and practices within the Department and its sectoral and attached agencies, and eventually catapult to other agencies and institutions, contributing to wider and all-encompassing environmental protection efforts of the archipelago.
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II. IMPACT AND SUSTAINABILITY OF THE ORGANISATIONAL OUTCOME OF THE REAP. The REAP should produce an output/s that will help the Host Organisation improve their services or performance. These improvements are the outcome/s of your REAP. You should therefore clearly articulate your strategies for the Host Organisation will sustain the gains of the REAP after its completion. (TIP: Based on our survey, the following factors ensure the effective implementation of REAP: the goals of the REAP should align with the goals of the Host Organisation and the Host Organisation is committed to the completion and full implementation of your REAP.)		
Development Sustainability	impact and	A project is future-proof successful when it is anchored on sustainability. Hence, the COMMUNIC-ACTION Manual — the pioneering blueprint for revolutionizing the strategic interdepartmental communications within the DOTr and its sectoral and attached agencies, aims to extend its vision far beyond its objectives. To institutionalize and sustain the gains slated to be reaped from the REAP, the following will be devised and done: Integration into the DOTr’s Organizational Policies, Procedures, and Structure. Effectively embed the unified, standardized communication framework, system, and protocols into the policies, procedures, and day-to-day operations of the DOTr-Central Communications, in association with its sectoral and attached agencies, to make it a timelessly relevant and applicable resource, not just for the DOTr staff alone, but will also extend to communication officers outside its premise, in the long run. Establishment of a Communication Governance Structure/or a Task Force. Form a dedicated communication governance structure—composed of the main focal person from each communication team (Central, sectoral, and attached agencies)—who will be tasked with coordinating and overseeing the implementation and maintenance of the communication system, framework, and protocols, including regular updates and audits. Training and Professional Development. The consistent roll out of training and development opportunities for the staff of the DOTr Communication Teams is vital to shore up the importance of effective, unified strategic interdepartmental communications and ensure its continued compliance with the proposed standardized system, as embedded in the COMMUNIC-ACTION Manual. Knowledge Management. The COMMUNIC-ACTION Manual, which shall serve as the pioneering comprehensive knowledge management plan vis-à-vis unified strategic interdepartmental communications, will be archived appropriately to ensure the facilitation of knowledge sharing and continuity for the future generation of information officers of the Department and its sectoral and attached agencies.

Organisational Outcome	The Re-entry Action Plan shall enhance the overall communication performance of the Department of Transportation (DOTr) in coordination with its attached and sectoral agencies. With a strengthened interdepartmental communication framework and system, a solid foundation towards better service delivery online and offline, organizational efficiency, and, more importantly, greater public trust and credibility. Thus, this will touch on not just one but multiple organizational outcomes within the host organization. Enhancement of Service Delivery: With the implementation of a standardized communication framework, system, and protocols and the improvement of interdepartmental coordination, disseminating information to the public and transport stakeholders will be streamlined, ensuring a more consistent and unified delivery of messages—thereby leading to increased transparency and trust in the Department. Improvement of Organizational Structure: As the anchor for the DOTr's Central Communications arm, this will provide a standardized framework and system for communication teams across the Department's attached and sectoral agencies. Delineating roles, responsibilities, and communication protocols will further strengthen the organizational structure to ensure better team collaboration and relationships. When the structure is improved, communication efforts will become more effective, ushering in enhanced organizational performance. System Development: The REAP outlines the need to develop new strategic communication systems while improving the existing ones, proving they are still effective. This includes creating protocols for information dissemination, establishing effective channels for internal and external communications, and viable deployment of technological solutions when necessary for efficient data sharing and teamwork. With these, the REAP will contribute to improving interdepartmental and organizational workflows and processes. Policy Evaluation and Formulation: Given that the COMMUNIC-ACTION shall be the pioneer manual for a strategic interdepartmental communication system, plan, and framework of the Department, this may encompass evaluating or assessing the existing communication policies, flow and practices, identifying gaps to be addressed, and creating new ones that will align with the proposed unified improvement. This will improve communication effectiveness and efficiency amongst the Department and its sectoral and attached agencies.
Output	The Re-Entry Action Plan (REAP) sets forth both tangible and intangible outputs that will synergistically work and collectively contribute to the attainment of the overarching organizational outcomes of enhancing the overall strategic, interdepartmental communication performance of the Department of Transportation (DOTr) and its sectoral and attached agencies. Tangible outputs include the creation of the pioneering blueprint and roadmap named as the "COMMUNIC-ACTION Manual", which encompasses the standardized communication framework, system, and protocols, along with the development of new strategic communication systems with viable technological assistance and support. These tangible outputs will streamline and unify information dissemination, improve interdepartmental coordination, enhance public service delivery—both online and offline—and provide a solid groundwork for organizational efficiency and workflow integration and optimization. The implementation of the COMMUNIC-ACTION Manual also serves forth

	strengthened interdepartmental relationships, cohesive and unified messaging, and clearer delineation of tasks, roles, and assignments, which shall then yield to intangible outputs of improved credibility and transparency toward the Department and its sectoral and attached agencies. Ultimately, all this will serve as crucial competency keys towards building a culture of effective and strategic government communications within the Department, to enhance public engagement and satisfaction.
Competencies	The COMMUNIC-ACTION Manual envisions to develop and broaden crucial and future-forward competencies in the field. First, it will hone the understanding of communication officers on strategic communication principles and concepts, which harps on the importance of transparency, accountability, and public engagement in government communications, with integrity and excellence at its core. Secondly, as the study underscores strategic interdepartmental communications, it will further amplify the communication teams' ken to navigate and manage communications processes within the DOTr and its sectoral and attached agencies, and shall equip them with the tools needed to maneuver and address challenges efficiently, fostering a culture of coherence and unification in the entire communication efforts of the Department. Meanwhile, it will bolster proficiency and aptitude in creating standardized communication systems, frameworks and protocols, to ensure consistency in the dissemination of information to the public and various transport stakeholders. Abilities in interdepartmental coordination and collaboration will likewise improve, which is vital in cultivating unity and fortifying the connection between the DOTr's Central Communications Team and the Communication Teams of the Department's sectoral and attached agencies. Ultimately, these competencies to be gained from the COMMUNIC-ACTION Manual will contribute to the efficient implementation of the proposed study's core aims. This shall pave the way further to solidify the DOTr's Central Communications arm, with the Communication Teams of the Department's sectoral and attached agencies, as beacons of effective and unified strategic government communications.

III. IMPLEMENTABILITY OF THE REAP. The REAP should be fully implemented within two years from when a scholar returns from Australia. The applicant should clearly and succinctly explain how he/she will implement the REAP within the required timeframe and budget. (TIP: The scale of your REAP should be within your circle of influence and control to ensure doability.)

Measurability

How will you track the progress of the implementation of your REAP? What are your milestones? Divide your REAP activities and timeline into four (4) milestones: 25%, 50%, 75% and 100%.

Action Steps (What activities will contribute to the milestones)	Expected Output	Timeline
25%		
Baseline Assessment and Gap Analysis	Assessment Report outlining the strengths, weaknesses, and improvement areas in the DOTr's current interdepartmental communication practices	1 month (January 2026)
50%		

Development of the COMMUNIC-ACTION Manual, and Approval of the Draft	Approved Document outlining the strategic interdepartmental communication plan, encompassing the unified, standardized communication framework, protocols, and system – embedded in the COMMUNIC-ACTION Manual. Approval of the draft, in consultation and alignment with the DOTr-Central Communications Team, obtained from the CCAO Head	3 months (February – April 2026)
75%		
Presentation and Capacity Building Training	Completion of presentation and training sessions to familiarize the DOTr-Central Communications Team with the COMMUNIC-ACTION Manual, and adopt it into the current system, and apply it to other communication teams of the DOTr's sectoral and attached agencies.	Monthly in 2026 (thereafter, quarterly)
100%		
Integration and Implementation	Successful roll out of the new strategic interdepartmental communication system, as embedded in the COMMUNIC-ACTION Manual, across the DOTr's communication teams, with the Central Comms as the core lead.	6 months (Starting June 2026)
Monitoring, Evaluation, and Feedback Mechanism for Continuous Improvement	A system is established for regular monitoring and evaluation to track the progress and impact on communication processes and outcomes of the COMMUNIC-ACTION Manual and identify areas for necessary adjustments. Further, a feedback mechanism has been implemented to help gather useful inputs for further enhancements.	After the roll-out of the COMMUNIC-ACTION Manual, and every 3 months for formative review

Resources	In implementing the COMMUNIC-ACTION Manual, the Department's current resources will be utilized efficiently. Government funding as a financial resource shall first be employed by looking through the internal funding allocations within the budget of the DOTr Communications and Commuter Affairs Office (CCAO), specifically related to crafting the strategic communications plan. In this approval process, the vital long-term opportunities and benefits of the REAP will be put forth, to position its crucial importance and role in the Department's communication arm. Meanwhile, existing training and development funds within the Department and its in-house facilities shall be utilized to cover the costs of workshops, training sessions, and in-house facilities. Moreover, should the internal funding allocation will not suffice for the other facets of the REAP, such as the technology assistance, evaluation and monitoring tool systems, and creation of the manual per se, among others, a multi-faceted approach or alternative solutions for obtaining the needed additional financial resources shall be done, such as undergoing a procurement process for further funding; cost-sharing agreement between the DOTr and its sectoral and attached agencies (Communication Offices); and, potential grants or sponsorship partnerships from other relative national government agencies that support initiatives promoting organizational efficiency and public service enhancement — all subject for approval.
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REAP Start Date and End Date	The REAP will be implemented in January 2026 and is slated to be completed by or before December 2026 (The start and end date will likewise depend on the specific month of arrival, upon the completion of the scholarship and study).
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RISKS AND MITIGATING MEASURE <i>Describe the risks that might impact on the success of the Action Plan and how you plan to manage these to ensure success. (Identify factors that will block/limit/slowdown accomplishment of intended results or lessen quality of outputs.)</i>	
<i>RISK</i>	<i>MITIGATING MEASURE</i>
Resistance to Standardization and Change. The various sectoral and attached agencies within the DOTr might have varying communication standards and practices, which might lead to resistance to adopting the proposed unified communication system.	The following shall be conducted: • Thorough stakeholder analysis to identify potential resistance points further and engage in communication and education campaigns to address related concerns. • Underscore the long-term advantages of the proposed unified interdepartmental communication plan, as embedded in the COMMUNIC-ACTION Manual, such as improved consistency, effectiveness, and efficient and cohesive information dissemination efforts. • Involvement of the DOTr Central Communication Teams and its sectoral and attached agencies, in the crafting of the COMMUNIC-ACTION Manual, paving the way for an open platform for relevant discussion. This emphasized their importance in the process. • Conduct proper guidance, support, and assistance — from transition to implementation and sustenance — to ensure the sustainable success of the unified and standardized interdepartmental communication system, framework, and protocols. • Moreover, monitor compliance and establish feedback loops to address deviations effectively and openly.
Interdepartmental Silos. Existing departmental silos might hinder effective coordination and collaboration across the DOTr's communication teams.	Foster a culture of collaboration and teamwork through leadership support and facilitation of regular cross-departmental workshops and meetings to enable open information sharing and synergy. Implementing the integration of the proposed communication system and protocols aims to break down these silos — allowing a seamless, smooth, and unified relationship and connection amongst the DOTr's communication teams (central and attached, and sectoral), which shall then strengthen and make the interdepartmental relationship more cohesive than before.
Lack of clear communication channels, which might lead to inefficiency and confusion.	Craft clear communication channels and centralized communication platform to ensure accessibility and transparency. Updates and guidelines shall be regularly communicated for clear alignment.

Technological Challenges. Insufficient technological capabilities might impede the implementation of the needed technology support for the communication system.

Conduct a thorough assessment of the current technological infrastructure and capabilities, and propose to invest in necessary upgrades and resources to support the proposal. Seek support, if viable, with the DOTr's technological staff to maximize efficient resource utilization. Contingency plans shall be established to address potential technological issues.

Signed by:



Chlarizel Dianne H. Pangan-Villa Agustin

Signed by:



Hector A. Villacorta

*Assistant Secretary, Communications and
Commuter Affairs Office*